

the british psychological society
partnership and accreditation

STANDARDS for the ACCREDITATION of UNDERGRADUATE, CONVERSION and INTEGRATED MASTER'S PROGRAMMES in PSYCHOLOGY

November 2024

BPS.ORG.UK/PARTNERSHIP

STANDARDS

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INTRODUCTION

BACKGROUND

The British Psychological Society ('the Society') is the learned and professional body, incorporated by Royal Charter, for psychology in the United Kingdom. The key objective of the Society is 'to promote the advancement and diffusion of the knowledge of psychology pure and applied and especially to promote the efficiency and usefulness of members by setting up a high standard of professional education and knowledge'. The purpose of the Society's accreditation process is to further that objective.

WHAT IS ACCREDITATION?

Accreditation through Partnership is the process by which the British Psychological Society works with education providers to ensure quality standards in education and training are met by all programmes on an ongoing basis. Our approach to accreditation is based on partnership rather than policing, and we emphasise working collaboratively with programme providers through open, constructive dialogue that allows for exploration, development and quality enhancement.

BENEFITS OF ACCREDITATION

Delivering a programme that meets the standards required for accreditation is a significant commitment, and there are many reasons why Society accreditation is worth your investment of time and money:

- It is a highly regarded marker of quality that prospective students and employers value.
- It enhances the marketability of your programmes.
- It gives your graduates a route to Society membership, an integral part of students' development as psychologists, or as part of the wider psychological workforce.
- It is a high quality benchmarking process aimed at getting the best out of programmes.
- It provides an opportunity for you and your students to influence the Society and its support for education providers and students.
- Together we have a powerful voice in raising the profile of psychology and psychological practice in the UK and internationally.

OUR STANDARDS

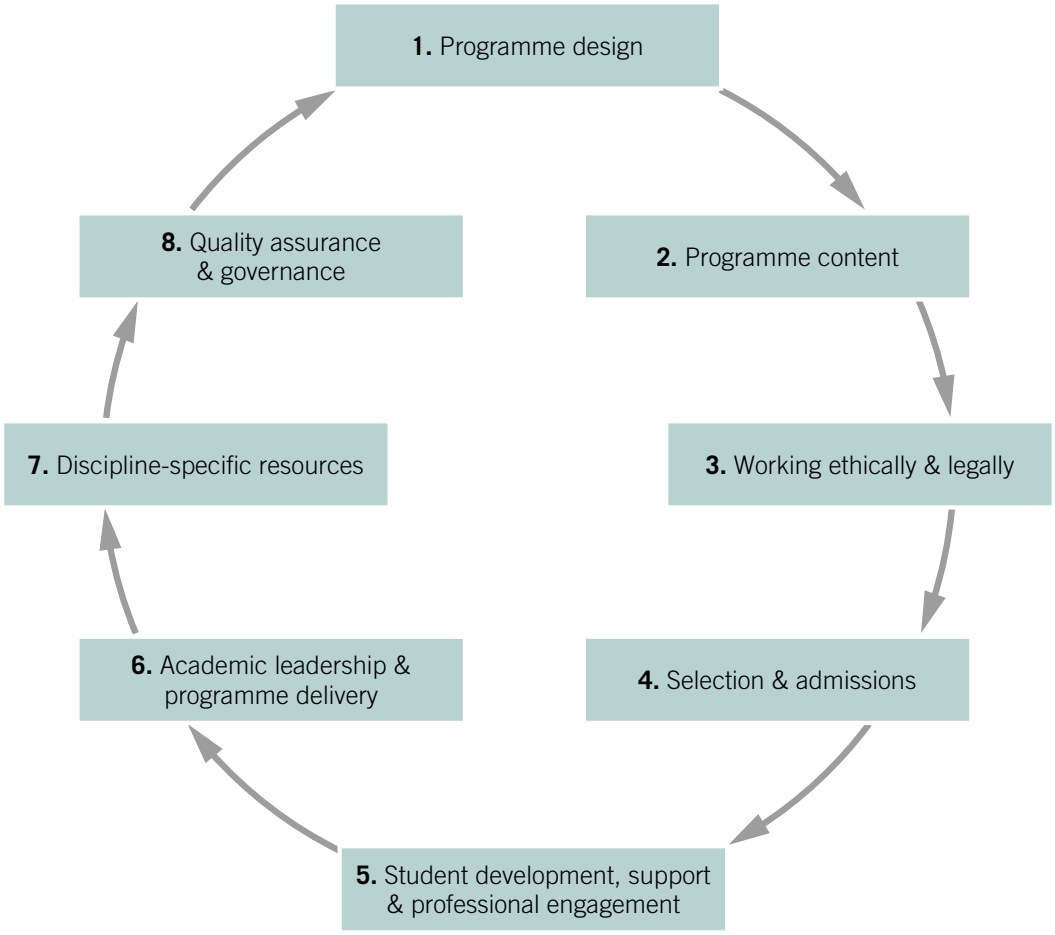
During 2023 and 2024, the Society's Partnership and Accreditation Committee (PAC) and its constituent Education and Training Committees reviewed the overarching programme standards, with the aim of providing greater clarity and more effective signposting to other relevant guidance in a way that is helpful to programmes when they articulate their work. This review of the programme standards has also provided the opportunity to embed the Society's commitment to promoting EDI within the discipline. Standards have been revised in accordance with the Quality Assurance Agency (QAA) Subject Benchmarking Standards for Psychology (2023).

The Education and Training Board (ETB) also reviewed the overarching programme standards, with the aim to supports the society in developing a strategy to enable delivery of an inclusive world class education and continuing professional development for psychologists and the wider psychological

workforce of all disciplines, which are appropriate, inclusive, relevant, robust and of high quality.

Our standards are intended to be applied flexibly, in a way that enables programmes to develop distinctive identities that make the most of particular strengths shared by their staff team, or those that are reflected in the strategic priorities of their department or university. During partnership visits, the questions that visiting teams will ask will be designed specifically to give education providers every opportunity to confirm their achievement of the standards.

Our standards are organised around eight overarching themes, as follows:



The standards have been derived following extensive consultation between the Society and education providers, and must be achieved and maintained by all accredited programmes. Each overarching standard is followed by a rationale for its inclusion, together with guidance and signposting of other relevant resources.

THIS DOCUMENT

This document sets out the accreditation standards for the accreditation of programmes in undergraduate, conversion and integrated Master's programmes in psychology. These standards came into operation on November 2024.

If you are submitting a new programme for accreditation, or are preparing for an accreditation visit or review, you should read these standards in conjunction with the relevant process handbook. All handbooks can be downloaded from bps.org.uk/accreditationdownloads.

Accredited undergraduate, conversion and integrated Master's programmes meet the requirements for the Graduate Basis for Chartered membership (GBC). Completion will provide a basis for progression to postgraduate training in psychology, and therefore eligibility for Chartered membership of the Society (CPsychol) in due course.

UNITED KINGDOM PROVISION

The Welsh Language Act 1993: This act requires that in the conduct of public business and the justice system in Wales, the Welsh language and English Language should be treated on a basis of equality.

ENGLISH

The Welsh Government is committed to creating an inclusive education system to help ensure that all young people have access to a high standard of education and reach their full potential.

Following the legislative guidance from The Welsh Language Standards (No.7) R 2018 programmes both taught and assessed in the Welsh language may seek accreditation.

WELSH

Mae Llywodraeth Cymru yn ymroddedig i greu system addysg gynhwysol i helpu i sicrhau bod gan bob unigolyn ifanc fynediad i addysg o safon uchel a'u bod yn cyrraedd eu llawn botensial.

Yn dilyn y canllawiau deddfwriaethol gan Reoliadau Safonau'r Gymraeg (Rhif 7) 2018 gall rhaglenni a addysgir ac a asesir yn Gymraeg geisio am achrediad.

IRISH & ULSTER SCOTS

The Northern Ireland Executive is committed to equal opportunities for all by giving due regard to national and cultural identity principles. The Identity and Language (Northern Ireland) Act (2022) makes provision for the official recognition of the Irish language and Ulster Scots in Northern Ireland. It also provides for the development of standards in relation to the use of the Irish language and Ulster Scots by public authorities. This includes provisions in relation to Irish medium education and facilitating the use of Ulster Scots in services to the public.

GAEILGE AGUS ALBANAIS ULADH

Tá Feidhmeannas Thuaisceart Éireann tiomanta do chomhionannas deiseanna do chách trí mheas a bheith aige ar phrionsabail na féiniúlachta náisiúnta agus cultúrtha. Tá fóráil d'aitheantas oifigiúil ar an Ghaeilge agus ar Albanais Uladh i dTuaisceart Éireann san Acht (Tuaisceart Éireann) um Fhéiniúlacht agus Theanga (2022). Tá fóráil ann fosta na caighdeáin a fhorbairt i dtaca le húdaráis phoiblí ag úsáid na Gaeilge agus Albanais Uladh. Tá forálacha san acht fosta maidir le Gaelscolaíocht agus le húsáid Albanais Uladh i seirbhísí don phobal a éascú.X

REGIONAL AND MINORITY LANGUAGES

In the interests of equity, diversity and inclusion, it is important to acknowledge other minority languages used in the British Isles. These languages have protected status as indigenous languages under the Council of Europe's Charter for Regional and Minority Languages, ratified by the Government in 1992. These languages include Manx and Cornish.



PROGRAMME STANDARDS

PROGRAMME STANDARD 1: PROGRAMME DESIGN

The design of the programme must ensure that successful achievement of the required programme learning outcomes is marked by the conferment of an award at the appropriate academic level. A commitment to advancing equality, sustainability, diversity and inclusion should be an underpinning principle of the programme design.

1.1 CREDITS AND LEVEL OF AWARD

1.1.1 Undergraduate programmes seeking accreditation against the requirements for the Graduate Basis for Chartered membership (GBC) must comprise a minimum of 360 credits, at least 50% of which must comprise psychology content and skills. This will comprise a minimum of 180 credits of the accredited award (240 credits in Scotland), and must result in the award of at least a Level 6 qualification (Level 10 in Scotland).

1.1.2 Master's conversion programmes seeking accreditation against the requirements for the GBC must comprise 180 credits in total, and must result in the award of a Level 7 qualification (Level 11 in Scotland).

1.1.3 Providers may also wish to put forward integrated Master's programmes:

- Integrated Master's programmes seeking accreditation against the requirements for the GBC must incorporate 120 Level 7 credits, and must result in the award of a Level 7 qualification (Level 11 in Scotland); e.g. MPsych.
- Integrated Master's programmes that seek to combine the requirements for the GBC and those for a stage one postgraduate training in forensic, health, occupational or sport and exercise psychology must incorporate 180 Level 7 credits, and must result in the award of a Level 7 qualification (Level 11 in Scotland). Such programmes will be evaluated against the two separate sets of standards they are seeking to meet (i.e. the standards contained in this handbook, and those applying to Master's programmes in the relevant modality).

1.2 DURATION AND LOCATION OF STUDIES

1.2.1 There is no minimum period of study for undergraduate, conversion or integrated Master's programmes. Full-time undergraduate programmes are delivered over three years or four years in Scotland (one year for conversion programmes). However, education providers are also able to submit shorter accelerated and longer integrated programmes for accreditation.

1.2.2 The Society does not stipulate a maximum study period within which an accredited programme must be completed.

1.2.3 Up to one third of the total credits of an accredited UK programme may be undertaken outside of the UK, however, the empirical project must be supervised and assessed by the accredited programme provider. Programmes should ensure access to study abroad is equitable and fair. Where a greater proportion of study is undertaken abroad, we consider this to be a separate programme requiring separate accreditation.

1.2.4 Where study abroad opportunities are available, the UK provider must ensure that the study abroad being undertaken allows students to cover all of the required curriculum appropriately by the time they have completed their programme (though not necessarily in the same way as others on their cohort), and that this learning will effectively support their progression.

1.3 AWARD NOMENCLATURE

1.3.1 The education provider must ensure that the title of any award accurately reflects the level of students' achievements and the intended learning outcomes of the programme content.

1.3.2 The degree title should appropriately represent the nature and field(s) of study undertaken and should not be misleading to prospective students, potential employers or to the general public with respect to programme content and the attainment of core psychological skills.

1.3.3 Undergraduate and Master's conversion awards are not allowed to use degree titles that are identical to, or include the titles of, postgraduate courses that lead to designated titles that are protected by law and regulated by the Health Care Professions Council (HCPC) (e.g. undergraduate Psychology degrees formally referred to as BSc Counselling Psychology or BSc Psychology with Clinical Psychology will be more appropriately referenced as BSc Psychology with Counselling and BSc Psychology with Clinical Perspectives).

1.4 ASSESSMENT REQUIREMENTS

1.4.1 Programmes must have in place an assessment strategy that maps clearly on to programme and module learning outcomes and incorporates a wide range of accessible and inclusive formative and summative assessments. It should reflect students' development of knowledge and skills as they progress through their studies and should be relevant to developing students' employability.

1.4.2 Programmes should articulate how advances in learning technology (e.g. Artificial Intelligence [AI]) can or cannot be used fairly, equitably and ethically within their assessment strategy.

1.4.3 Each of the core content areas specified in Programme Standard 2, below, must be summatively assessed at the appropriate level in breadth and depth, but need not be assessed separately (with the exception of the empirical project).

1.4.4 Education providers must include a statement in their programme handbook(s) (or equivalent document) advising students that, in order to be eligible for the GBC, they must pass the empirical psychology project, and gain at least a Lower Second Class Honours degree, or its equivalent. For the Master's conversion degree, students must pass the empirical psychology project and achieve an overall pass mark of at least 50% to be eligible for GBC.

1.4.5 Assessment rules, regulations and other criteria should be published in a full and accessible form and made freely available to students, staff and external examiners. This should include an explanation of the providers AI policy as well as programme specific guidance on the fair use of AI.

1.4.6 Assessment practices should be accessible, fair, valid, reliable, and appropriate to the level of the award being offered.

1.4.7 Assessment designs should include authentic assessments and assessments that prepare students to address sustainability challenges and enter a range of graduate and/or professional careers.

1.4.8 Assessment should be designed, implemented and graded only by appropriately qualified staff, who have been adequately trained and briefed, and given regular opportunities to enhance their expertise as assessors.

1.4.9 Education providers should have in place policies and procedures to deal thoroughly, fairly and expeditiously with problems which arise in the assessment of students in a transparent way. These should include the grounds for student appeals against assessment outcomes, and the process that students should follow if they wish to pursue an appeal.

1.4.10 Education providers should ensure that detailed and up to date records on student progress and achievement are kept.

1.4.11 Throughout a programme of study, students should receive timely and constructive feedback about their performance in relation to assessment criteria to support their subsequent learning activities. Providers should ensure students are informed of the feedback turnaround times and that this allows sufficient time for students to apply feedback to future learning.

1.5 INCLUSIVE AND EQUITABLE ASSESSMENT

1.5.1 Education providers should have inclusive teaching and assessment strategies in place that anticipate the diverse needs, backgrounds and abilities of students.

1.5.2 Where reasonable adjustments need to be made for students with disabilities or students with additional needs, these should apply to the form and process of assessment, and not to the learning outcomes being assessed.

RATIONALE FOR INCLUSION

The Society has clear expectations about teaching, learning and assessment on accredited programmes, and the provisions that should be built into the design of those programmes to ensure quality. The standards outlined above will ensure that those seeking entry to specific grades of Society membership on the basis of having completed an accredited programme have met the stipulations set out in the Society's *Royal Charter, Statutes and Rules.*

GUIDANCE AND SIGNPOSTING

- Part A of the UK Quality Code for Higher Education (qaa.ac.uk) addresses setting and maintaining academic standards, and signposts relevant qualifications and credit frameworks, as well as guidance on the characteristics of different qualifications. Providers may also find it helpful to refer to a further five chapters from Part B of the Quality Code (qaa.ac.uk):
  - Chapter B1: Programme design, development and approval
  - Chapter B3: Learning and teaching
  - Chapter B6: Assessment of students and the recognition of prior learning
  - Chapter B9: Academic appeals and student complaints
  - Chapter B11: Research degrees
  - *UK Quality Code, Advice and Guidance: Assessment* (2018)
- The Equality Challenge Unit has produced guidance on *Managing Reasonable Adjustments in Higher Education*, which providers may find helpful (advance-he.ac.uk).
- The Society's accreditation standards make provision for students to undertake some study or placement time abroad as part of their programme (up to one third of the total credits of the accredited programme). Study abroad opportunities may not be available for all students, and arrangements will vary across different providers. Where study abroad opportunities are available, the UK provider must ensure that the study abroad being undertaken allows students to cover all of the required curriculum appropriately by the time they have completed their programme (though not necessarily in the same way as others on their cohort), and that this learning will effectively support their progression. It is recommended that equality impact assessments are conducted on programme options such as study abroad, placements and internships, in order to identify and mitigate against any negative impacts on advancing EDI within the discipline. More detailed information is available in our guide to studying abroad on an accredited programme, which can be downloaded from bps.org.uk/accreditation/education-providers
- Where more than one third of the total credits for the programme are undertaken outside of the UK, the Society considers this to be a separate programme requiring separate accreditation. Information regarding the Society's international accreditation process can be found at bps.org.uk/accreditation/education-providers

- The Society does not specify a maximum study period for an accredited programme. It is expected that individual education providers will have in place regulations governing the maximum permissible period of time that may elapse from initial enrolment to completion, regardless of individual circumstances, to ensure the currency of their knowledge, their competence, and the award conferred upon them, whilst also ensuring the programme is accessible to a diverse range of students.
- **Equality, Diversity, and Inclusion: Inclusive programme design: Ongoing revisions/ modifications:** Inclusive participation is the key principle, enabling involvement, especially from underrepresented groups and will create a more engaging programme that responds to the interests, needs and priorities of all cohorts. It is also a process that supports a dialogue between students/stakeholders and the professionals. The process needs to be safe, enabling and inclusive, and it is of itself a valuable learning experience, supporting inquiry and critical thinking for all. Important factors such as language usage and social contexts should be a focal point and this will nurture the integration of cultural diversity across the programme.
- **Sustainable Development:** Sustainable Development Goals and Education for Sustainable Development: Psychology has a clear role to play in responding to the challenges/ opportunities identified by the UN's SDGs. Programmes should be mindful of the of their role in developing the knowledge, skills and values that students require to contribute to sustainable development. The key competences identified by UNESCO (i.e. ways of thinking, practicing and being) are core to the Psychology curriculum and will provide graduates with the foundation to contribute to evidence-based policy and interventions. Programmes should ensure that appropriate pedagogical practices are in place to support such development.
- **Enterprise and entrepreneurship education:** education relating to enterprise and entrepreneurship can take many forms and can be included in the core domains of psychology, via work placements or involvement with external organisations. The skills embedded within psychology are highly relevant to entrepreneurship and enterprise activity and providing students with the opportunity to develop and apply such skills can impact on students' employability. Furthermore, developing students' skills and behaviours in this area creates a mindset that enables students to add social, economic and cultural value to society.
- All accredited programmes are required to review the design, structure and content of their programmes so that they can meet the ever-changing needs of students, technological changes, changing social contexts and needs. This is especially pertinent to any online/ blended learning programmes where technology advances at a significant pace and the need to review recorded material is paramount. Please see the Supplementary Guidance for Accredited Online, Blended, and Distance learning Supplementary Guidance for Accredited Online, Blended, and Distance Learning Programmes (June 2021). After consulting with providers, the Partnership and Accreditation Team have developed new supplementary guidance now available on the BPS website at the following link.

PROGRAMME STANDARD 2: PROGRAMME CONTENT (LEARNING, RESEARCH, PRACTICE)

The programme must reflect contemporary learning, research and practice in psychology.

2.1 PROGRAMME CONTENT REQUIREMENTS

The Quality Assurance Agency for Higher Education (QAA) publishes a Subject Benchmark Statement for Psychology the UK Quality Code for Higher Education (qaa.ac.uk) that defines what can be expected of a graduate in the subject, in terms of what they might know, do and understand at the end of their studies. The application of knowledge, skills and ethical awareness, known as Psychological Literacy, is an integral part of a psychology degree. In recognition of the Society's Equality, Diversity and Inclusion (EDI) Framework and its commitment to promoting EDI within the discipline, programme teams are expected to ensure the programme content is inclusive of those with protected characteristics and reflects culturally and socially diverse perspectives. The current Subject Benchmark Statement was published in 2023 and outlines the following principles that guide a degree programme in psychology. Degrees in psychology:

- aim to produce a critical and scientific understanding of the mind, brain, behaviour and experience, in relation to the complex environments' and socio-cultural contexts with in which they exist;
- include the development of knowledge and the acquisition of a range of methods of research and enquiry for investigating experience and behaviour, that enable students to take a lead role in research and enquiry, as well as participating as part of a team;
- develop an understanding of the role of empirical evidence in the creation and constraint of theory, and also in how theory guides the collection and interpretation of empirical data;
- present multiple perspectives in a way that fosters critical evaluation and reflection;
- develop knowledge, leading to a critical appreciation of theory and research findings, including relevant ethical and socio-cultural issues;
- lead to an understanding of real life applications of theory to the full range of experience and behaviour and the application of psychological understanding to real world questions; and
- develop psychological literacy to ensure the use of disciplinary knowledge, theoretical understanding, principles and insight to respond to opportunities and challenges.

This practical application of knowledge, skills and ethical awareness is developed throughout, and made explicit when focused on working ethically beyond research and data collection, and when developing employability skills and professional integrity.

Programmes that are designed to meet the requirements for the GBC should equip psychology graduates with the knowledge and skills that are outlined in Section 3 of the Subject Benchmark Statement where it states:

Students are able to:

- understand the conceptual and historical underpinnings of psychology as a discipline;
- apply multiple perspectives to psychological issues, recognising that psychology involves a range of methods of research and enquiry, theories, evidence, interpretations and applications;
- integrate ideas and findings across multiple perspectives and approaches in psychology and apply psychological knowledge ethically, professionally and safely to real-world problems;
- identify, contextualise and evaluate diverse patterns in behaviour, psychological functioning and experience;
- apply critical thinking skills to address complex problems to identifying creative and innovative solutions;
- generate and explore appropriate psychological hypotheses and research questions drawing on relevant theory, research and practice, design studies and collect original data;
- apply a variety of methods of inquiry, such as experiments, observation, questionnaires, psychometric tests, interviews, focus groups, creative methods or secondary data analysis;
- understand and appreciate the value of participatory and/or action research and user involvement in research and community and peer research;
- analyse, present and evaluate quantitative, qualitative data and mixed methods data and critique research findings;
- manage, synthesise and evaluate potentially conflicting sources such as primary research studies or theories;
- employ evidence-based reasoning and examine practical, theoretical and ethical issues associated with a range of methods of inquiry and other activities;
- use and critique a variety of psychological tools, including specialist software, laboratory equipment, and psychometric instruments;
- critically and reflectively evaluate psychological theory and research;
- understand and apply the process of theory development and be capable of developing theory driven psychological questions; and
- carry out an extensive independent piece of empirical research that requires students individually to demonstrate a range of research skills, including designing and planning, considering and resolving ethical issues, analysis and dissemination of findings.

2.1.1 In order to support students' development of the above knowledge and skills, accredited programmes must deliver the curriculum below. The core domains and suggested topic areas within those domains are predominantly taken from Section 3 (Content, structure and delivery) of the Subject Benchmark Statement (qaa.ac.uk) (2023) Where the curriculum information below does not refer directly to the corresponding section of the Subject Benchmark Statement, additional guidance on the Society's expectations has been provided as appropriate.

2.1.2 The full GBC curriculum must be delivered (taught and summatively assessed) at Level 4, Level 5 or Level 6, as defined by the *Framework for Higher Education Qualifications* (this is equivalent to Levels 8, 9 and 10 of the Scottish Credit and Qualifications Framework), with the exception of the empirical project, which must be delivered at Level 6 or at Level 10 in Scotland. Where core areas are delivered at Level 4, this must be supported by additional coverage (teaching and summative assessment) at Level 5 or Level 6 that progresses students' knowledge and understanding in relation to those core areas. This approach will enable providers to achieve breadth of coverage at Level 4 (SCQF Level 8) and encourages providers adopting this model to pursue depth of coverage at Level 5 or Level 6 (SCQF Level 9 and 10), in a way that reflects the particular strengths of the department in which the provision is based. In the case of Master's programmes the core material must be delivered at Level 7 (SCQF Level 11). This is designed to allow greater flexibility and support and encourage integration across the curriculum where education providers wish to do so. Specific expectations in relation to these aspects of the curriculum are outlined in the relevant sections below.

2.1.3 Education providers offering conversion programmes will need to demonstrate how their students attain both breadth and depth in the GBC curriculum areas and are assessed at the appropriate level (Level 7; Level 11 of the SCQF). In circumstances where Master's conversion students are taught alongside undergraduate students, differentiation of content, learning outcomes and assessment must be clearly demonstrated.

2.1.4 The GBC curriculum is as follows:

a. Biological psychology

e.g. biological bases of human and non-human behaviour, brain structure and function, hormones and behaviour, behavioural genetics, neuroscience, psychopharmacology, neuropsychology, comparative and evolutionary psychology. [Section 3.4 Subject Benchmark Statement].

b. Cognitive psychology

e.g. attention, perception, learning, memory, thinking, problem-solving, decision-making, metacognition, language, consciousness, artificial intelligence, cognitive neuropsychology, cognitive bias, and social cognition. [Section 3.4 Subject Benchmark Statement].

c. Developmental psychology

e.g. attachment, social relations, cognitive and language development, cognitive decline, biological aging and cultural development, with reference to development across the full lifespan - prenatal, childhood, adolescence, adulthood, older age and death [Section 3.4 Subject Benchmark Statement].

d. Individual differences

e.g. diversity in personality, intelligence, cognitive style, emotion, motivation, mood, physical and mental health (including social, biological and cognitive processes), as well as positive psychology. [Section 3.4 Subject Benchmark Statement].

e. Social psychology

e.g. citizenship, community psychology, attribution, attitudes, group processes and intergroup relations, social influence, leadership, political psychology, culture, close relationships and sexualities, social constructionism, power, powerlessness and empowerment, and self and identities in context. [Section 3.4 Subject Benchmark Statement].

f. Conceptual and historical issues in psychology

e.g. epistemological and ontological issues underpinning a foundation in the philosophy of science, historical and contemporary positions within psychology, the dominance and impact of privileged positions within psychology, and the value of interdisciplinary approaches. [Sections 3.5 Subject Benchmark Statement].

g. Research methods

It is good practice to introduce methods of research and enquiry at Level 4 and develop the student's breadth and depth of understanding and skills in these areas throughout the programme. Research methods are integral to psychology and students should obtain a sound knowledge of, and demonstrate the ability to use, a range of quantitative, qualitative and mixed methods appropriately. Knowledge and critical understanding of how to obtain and analyse evidence is best acquired and demonstrated through extensive and progressive empirical work in laboratory and naturalistic settings through all stages of a degree. For accreditation, methods of research and enquiry must be delivered and summatively assessed at Level 5 or Level 6; however, students must have sufficient coverage and experience of data collection and conducting research using a range of quantitative, qualitative and mixed methods so that they are able to undertake an empirical project using any methodology. This is of importance in the consideration of the design of conversion programmes and providers must ensure that students are adequately prepared to undertake an empirical project. [Section 3.4 Subject Benchmark Statement].

QAA BENCHMARK STATEMENT

3.6 Rigour in research design and methods of enquiry is integral to Psychology. Students obtain a sound knowledge of, and demonstrate an ability to use, interpret, and disseminate a range of qualitative, quantitative, and mixed methods, as appropriate to the research question. Knowledge and understanding of how to operationalise research questions, investigate psychological phenomena and select appropriate measures is required. In particular, this includes the ability to design, obtain, analyse, and disseminate evidence. Relevant knowledge and understanding are best acquired and demonstrated through extensive and progressive empirical work in laboratories (physical or virtual) and naturalistic settings through all stages of a course.

Psychology students are required to learn the principles of sound and ethical data collection and socially responsible research (e.g. open science). Given the broad theoretical scope of Psychology, rigorous specialist training is required to develop a critical understanding of the range of methods of research and enquiry, the choice of research methods employed, and the analytic approach taken, for developing and testing psychological theories. These principles will also inform the application of psychological methods to local, national and global real-world problems. [Section 3.5 Subject Benchmark Statement].

QAA BENCHMARK STATEMENT

3.10 Psychology students learn the basic principles of sound ethical data collection and socially responsible research - for example, with open science and pre-registration. Given the broad theoretical scope of Psychology, rigorous specialist training is required to engender a critical understanding of the role of research design and enquiry. This includes the choice of research methods employed. It extends to analytic approaches taken for developing, testing and refining psychological theories. And it applies psychological methods and approaches to real world problems – locally, nationally and globally

Programmes' coverage of methods of research and enquiry should support students' engagement with the sub-areas listed above (i.e 2.1.4 a to f), and should be directed towards supporting students' attainment of the subject-specific skills highlighted in Section 3.16 of the Subject Benchmark Statement. As they progress through the programme, students should be able to:

- apply multiple perspectives to psychological issues, recognising that psychology involves a range of methods of research and enquiry, theories, evidence and applications;
- demonstrate knowledge of quantitative, qualitative and mixed methods and their underlying assumptions, principles, relative applications, strengths and weaknesses;
- integrate ideas and findings across the multiple perspectives in psychology and recognise distinctive psychological approaches to relevant issues;
- identify and evaluate patterns in behaviour, psychological functioning and experience;
- generate and explore hypotheses and research questions drawing on relevant theory and research;
- carry out empirical studies involving a variety of methods of data collection, including experiments, observation, questionnaires, psychometric instruments, interviews and focus groups;
- analyse, present and evaluate quantitative and qualitative data and evaluate research findings;
- employ evidence-based reasoning and examine practical, theoretical and ethical issues associated with the range of methodologies;

- use a variety of psychological tools, including specialist software, laboratory equipment and psychometric instruments;
- apply psychological knowledge ethically and safely to real world problems; and
- critically evaluate psychological theory and research and engage with the challenges and opportunities of applying these to policy, practice and beyond.

More specifically we would expect that students should be able to:

- identify and categorise different types of quantitative data (e.g. categorical, continuous), clean and manage data, and represent data visually (e.g. histograms, line graphs);
- formulate and operationalize research questions and hypotheses, drawing on relevant theory and research and explain the difference between a research question and hypothesis;
- identify basic study designs, differentiate exploratory and confirmatory research, and apply experimental and non-experimental research designs;
- calculate descriptive statistics (e.g. mean, interquartile range) and explain how descriptive and inferential statistics differ;
- identify and explain sources of bias (e.g. sampling bias), cognitive biases (e.g. confirmation bias) questionable research practices (e.g. selective reporting), generalisability and robustness, research misconduct, replication studies and reproducibility;
- understand several qualitative methods, perform qualitative analyses, present qualitative research, and critically appraise qualitative research (e.g. using qualitative criteria); and
- explain the difference between statistical significance and practical significance.

To achieve the above subject-specific skills, accredited providers should ensure that:

1. Students are critically engaged with the strengths and weaknesses of methods of research and enquiry, including mixed-methods designs.
2. Students are provided with a range of opportunities to generate hypotheses and research questions, to collect primary data and to write up at least 2 full research reports (i.e. review of relevant literature, explanation of methodology, data analysis and evaluation/discussion of findings) with a minimum of 1 qualitative and 1 quantitative report for summative assessment at Level 5 and Level 9 in Scotland (Level 7 for Conversion programmes, Level 11 in Scotland)..
3. Students are taught to critically engage with the challenges and opportunities of applying psychological theory and research to policy, practice and real-world problems.
4. Students are taught about and understand the principles of Open Science and are aware of issues around replicability and reproducibility in empirical research.
5. Students engage in academic writing using a standard academic referencing style.

h. Empirical project

Students will complete an empirical project reporting on a substantial piece of research (or a piece of work which delivers the same learning outcomes of equal quality). Empirical projects (even where the final award is a joint honours degree) must have a psychological focus. The psychology project typically involves the collection of original empirical data from participants, or equivalent alternatives such as computational modelling of empirical data or secondary data analysis, such as a meta-analysis [Section 3.11 Subject Benchmark Statement]. Literature reviews/ narrative reviews/systematic reviews are not considered to be acceptable alternatives to the empirical project.

QAA BENCHMARK STATEMENT

3.11 A graduate of Psychology will have successfully completed a series of research reports throughout their course, culminating in an empirical project or equivalent reporting on a substantial piece of research. The project involves the collection of original quantitative, qualitative or mixed methods data, or equivalent alternatives such as computational modelling or secondary data analysis.

The empirical practical component will involve the completion of a psychology project at Level 6 (SCQF Level 10) or the case of Master's conversion degrees, Level 7 (SCQF Level 11). The project must be passed and cannot be condoned or compensated.

The empirical psychology project will include carrying out an extensive piece of empirical research that requires the student to individually demonstrate a range of research skills including reviewing and establishing a theoretical understanding of the phenomenon of interest, formulating appropriate research questions or hypotheses, identifying an appropriate research design and associated methods of data collection, engaging in an ethical approval process, considering and resolving ethical issues and appropriately analysing and reporting the data in line with good scientific practice. [Section 3.11 Subject Benchmark Statement].

Students may undertake their empirical projects as part of a project or laboratory group, however, they are still required to demonstrate all of the above skills individually. In these circumstances students must complete an individual final report including a review of literature, methodology, data analysis and evaluation/discussion of findings.

Empirical projects should be written using a standard academic referencing and formatting system (e.g. APA, Harvard).

2.2 TEACHING AND LEARNING

2.2.1 A clear programme specification must be in place that provides a concise description of the intended learning outcomes of the programme, and which helps students to understand the teaching and learning methods that enable the learning outcomes to be achieved, and the assessment methods that enable achievement to be demonstrated with adequate breadth and depth. The programme specification (and any module specifications) must include learning outcomes that reflect the specific programme content requirements outlined above.

2.2.2 Education providers must be able to document the intended programme and module learning outcomes, and the ways in which these are mapped on to the programme content requirements outlined above.

2.2.3 Education providers must have in place an inclusive teaching, learning and assessment strategy that ensures adequate breadth, depth and progression of coverage of GBC curriculum areas. Programmes may provide broad coverage of core areas at Level 4. Where this is the case, progression and depth of knowledge must be provided at Level 5 or Level 6 (SCQF Levels 9 and 10). Adequacy of coverage will be evaluated against the range of example topics given in this handbook. Reviewers will explore the rationale for coverage of individual GBC curriculum areas only where an area is represented very narrowly, or where a major topic (as listed above) is missing.

2.2.4 Education providers must deliver content that demonstrates how students can apply research methods and psychological literacy in diverse real-world situations, as well as academic and non-academic employment pathways.

2.2.5 Students are entitled to expect an inclusive learning experience which meets their diverse needs, and which is underpinned by competent, research-informed teaching, and a supportive and enabling learning environment.

2.2.6 Teaching and learning practices should provide students with authentic learning experiences, which are inclusive, diverse and focus on the development of psychological literacy.

2.2.7 Raising awareness of digital competencies should be embedded into the curriculum to ensure that students are familiar with them and understand that when using digital competences and working digitally, it is important that students adhere to the usual conduct and ethical guidelines that inform their research and studies.

2.3 RESEARCH

2.3.1 Education providers must be able to demonstrate how they have taken account of the Society's Supplementary guidelines for research and research methods in designing, developing and delivering their research methods and project provision.

2.3.2 The QAA Subject Benchmark Statement for Psychology outlines the importance of practical based learning and associated assessment to the development of students' understanding of psychology and the opportunities available to them to demonstrate the subject-specific skills outlined in this handbook, including completion of an empirical psychology project. The curriculum requirements above outline the need for practical work to cover a wide variety of methodologies, including quantitative, qualitative and mixed methods. Students should be exposed to a wide range of topics

reflecting the academic content of psychology through providing opportunities to engage in practical work. Practical work is considered to be an experiential activity in which students apply their conceptual psychological understanding through means of methodologically appropriate tasks. Accredited programmes will be expected to demonstrate the ways in which they accommodate these expectations.

2.4 APPLICATION OF PSYCHOLOGY

2.4.1 Education providers must be able to demonstrate how they develop students' applied understanding of psychological literacy. They should provide accessible opportunities for students to gain experience of the application of psychological knowledge and skills to inform their career choices within and beyond professions in psychology.

RATIONALE FOR INCLUSION

The Society's standards for accredited programmes reflect contemporary theory, research and practice, enabling accredited programmes to develop psychologists who will be fit for purpose for the future. They also reflect the Society's commitment to advance EDI within the discipline. As such, these reflect the optimal academic and professional standards, promoted by the Society through the award of Graduate membership (MBPsS) and the Graduate Basis for Chartered membership (GBC), and Chartered membership (CPsychol) respectively. The Society is keen that these standards create flexibility for programmes to develop distinctive identities, by making the most of particular strengths around research and practice shared by their staff team, or those that are reflected in the strategic priorities of their department or university.

GUIDANCE AND SIGNPOSTING

- Education providers are free to map topics in any academically coherent combination, which could range from delivering core content areas within dedicated modules, or embedding coverage across a number of modules. The Society encourages programmes to deliver core content across modules within an integrated and inclusive curriculum that offers a pedagogical development of students' knowledge, understanding, and skills.
- Programme teams may find beneficial the use of sector-wide developed toolkits that aim to decolonise the curriculum, in order to include more culturally and socially diverse perspectives.
- Providers may find it helpful to refer to Chapter B3 of the UK Quality Code for Higher Education, which addresses Learning and Teaching.
- The Society has produced *Supplementary Guidelines for Research and Research Methods on Society Accredited Undergraduate and Conversion Programmes*, which was published in April 2017.

PROGRAMME STANDARD 3: WORKING ETHICALLY AND LEGALLY

The programme must develop and evaluate students' understanding of working ethically and legally and develop students' awareness of historical and contemporary issues (e.g. marginalisation and the abuse of power) that have impacted on research practice and engagement.

3.1 All accredited programmes must develop students' understanding of ethics and include teaching and assessment on the Society's *Code of Ethics and Conduct* and relevant supplementary ethical guidelines e.g. Guidance on teaching and assessment of ethical competence in psychology education.

3.2 Programmes must include teaching on ethical issues in research including ethical issues raised by specific research designs, samples and contexts (e.g. online research, those unable to provide informed consent). Teaching should also address the potential consequences and misuse of study findings and their potential impact on wider society.

3.3 Accredited programmes must have mechanisms in place to ensure that all research undertaken by students that involves human participants is conducted in line with the Society's *Code of Human Research Ethics*. This should include all occasions where data is collected from students, such as laboratory sessions and workshops, where students should be afforded their rights and dignity as participants in accordance with the Society's *Code of Human Research Ethics*.

3.4 It is expected that all programmes develop students' understanding of professional conduct and language that is inclusive and respectful of others. It is the responsibility of the programme team to lead by example and uphold high standards of professionalism, promote ethical and sustainable behaviour and follow the Society's *Code of Ethics and Conduct.*

3.5 All research conducted as part of the final year empirical project (i.e. L6 in England and Wales, L10 in Scotland and L7 and L11 for Conversion degrees in England and Wales and Scotland, respectively) must have ethical approval. In most circumstances students will complete an individual ethics form to obtain that approval. Where group projects are conducted or where ethical approval for the work has been previously obtained, each student must complete an individual ethics form (and respond to feedback when provided) to ensure their understanding of ethical issues though these forms may not be part of the formal ethical application. This process applies to projects using both primary and secondary data.

3.6 Programmes must ensure that students are taught and summatively assessed on ethics and understanding of professional conduct beyond the submission of ethics applications for research projects.

3.7 Students should be encouraged to develop psychological literacy, learning how they can apply their knowledge and skills in real world settings whilst understanding the expectations and legal responsibilities regarding working outside of their competence (e.g. applications within protected domains which require stage two postgraduate qualifications).

3.8 Programmes must provide guidance and instruction to students outlining appropriate levels of activity (e.g. with respect to placement activity and the use of the title 'psychologist' and the misuse of practitioner psychologist titles). Stage 1 students are not permitted to work with clients or deliver interventions.

3.9 Programmes must acknowledge the broader role of professional and statutory regulatory bodies including the distinct role of the Society as the professional body for psychology, and the Health and Care Professions Council as the statutory regulator for practitioner psychologists in the UK. Programmes should have mechanisms in place to signpost students to these for other related professions (e.g. counselling).

3.10 For programmes with students based overseas, content should include relevant information (ethical issues, professional conduct, professional bodies) for both the UK and the local context.

RATIONALE FOR INCLUSION

The inclusion of this standard reflects the particular importance of ethics and ethical practice to psychologists, and to the Society as the professional body for psychology graduates, and psychological practitioners specifically. Students on accredited programmes need to be able to: Identify the presence of an ethical issue (ethical sensitivity); formulate the morally ideal course of action by identifying the relevant ethical issues and using these principles to consider appropriate actions (ethical reasoning); decide what they wish and intend to do (ethical motivation); and execute and implement what they intend to do (ethical implementation). They also need to develop commitment to the ethical principles of respect, competence, responsibility, and integrity – as appropriate to their level of study. In addition, all prospective psychologists and psychological practitioners need to understand the legislative and regulatory requirements that apply to psychological practice in the UK. This standard therefore differentiates between working ethically and working legally to reflect the above considerations.

ETHICS REVIEW AND INDEPENDENT RESEARCH WITH HUMAN PARTICIPANTS

The Society Ethics Committee can provide support through published and informal ethics advice. Published guidance includes:

- *The Code of Ethics and Conduct;*
- *The Code of Human Research Ethics;*
- *Statement of Policy on Authorship and Publication Credit;* and
- *Guidance for the Conduct of Internet Mediated Research*.

The Committee can also provide confidential informal advice, based on the best practice set out in these publications, to queries submitted to ethical.enquiries@bps.org.uk.

GUIDANCE AND SIGNPOSTING

- The Society's *Code of Ethics and Conduct*, *Code of Human Research Ethics*, and supplementary ethical guidelines provide clear ethical principles, values and standards to guide and support psychologists' decisions in the difficult and challenging situations they may face. Further information can be found at bps.org.uk/ethics.
- The Society's Ethics Committee has produced *Guidance on Teaching and Assessment of Ethical Competence in Psychology Education* (2015), which outlines ethical competencies, and how these may be taught and assessed at different levels of study. Programmes are encouraged to make use of the guidance as appropriate to their provision.
- The Health and Care Professions Council has produced a learning resource that is designed to support the understanding of ethical issues that individuals may encounter. Whilst it is primarily intended to contextualise the HCPC's *Guidance on Conduct and Ethics for Students*, it presents useful resources for students at all levels of study.
- All accredited programmes are expected to include formal teaching on ethics and ethical practices, and should be able to demonstrate how working ethically is integral to all aspects of their provision, including research (as outlined below), and placement activities (where applicable). The assessment strategy for the programme should consider understanding of ethical principles as appropriate to the level of study.
- Students need to understand the ethical frameworks that apply to their research, and how to engage with these, as well as understanding the ethical implications of the research that they encounter. They also need to understand ethics as applied to working with people more generally.
- Providers should have in place mechanisms for identifying and dealing with academic and (where applicable) professional misconduct. The programme should consider the ways in which these mechanisms are publicised.

PROGRAMME STANDARD 4: SELECTION AND ADMISSIONS

The programme must apply appropriate selection and entry criteria that are consistent with promoting equality of opportunity and access to psychology to as diverse a range of applicants as possible.

4.1 EQUALITY, DIVERSITY AND INCLUSION

The programme must implement and monitor equality, diversity and inclusion policies (e.g. equality impact assessments) in relation to applicants.

4.2 SELECTION AND ENTRY REQUIREMENTS

4.2.1 For undergraduate, intercalated awards and integrated Masters programmes, entry requirements should be established by the education provider.

4.2.2 **Conversion programmes:** Conversion programmes offer an opportunity for students to 'convert' their existing qualifications and learning to an award that meets the requirements for the GBC. Education providers offer conversion awards that comprise 180 credits, and the standards outlined above set 180 credits in psychology as a minimum requirement for the GBC.

- All applicants to conversion programmes must hold a degree-level qualification (Level 6, or Level 10 in Scotland, or higher). This may include a degree in a subject other than psychology, or a degree in psychology that has not been accredited by the Society. The latter may also include applicants who have undertaken an accredited degree, but who have failed to either pass the empirical psychology project, or achieve at least a Lower Second Class Honours degree.

4.2.3 **Intercalated awards:** All applicants to intercalated awards must have passed the required amount of credits for a degree qualification (up to level 6, or Level 10 in Scotland, or higher).

Education providers may offer intercalated awards that comprise either 120 or 180 credits, however students will need to meet the standards outlined above which set 180 credits in psychology as a minimum requirement for the GBC.

4.3 RECOGNITION OF PRIOR LEARNING:

4.3.1 Where the education provider offers applicants the opportunity to seek exemption from undertaking a proportion of the programme, effective processes should be in place for assessing and recognising their prior learning and experience.

4.3.2 Education providers wishing to admit students to an accredited programme with advanced standing (e.g. direct entry to year two of a programme) may operate procedures for the recognition of prior learning (RPL) against the learning outcomes of the accredited award. Students may transfer from one accredited programme to another at any time. However, procedures for the recognition of prior learning must ensure that all graduates from accredited programmes have covered all of the GBC Curriculum areas by the time they complete their studies.

4.3.3 The following exclusions apply to the recognition of prior learning:

- For conversion programmes, recognition of prior learning is limited to a maximum of 60 credits in psychology.
- Recognition of prior experiential (or informal) learning is not permitted for conversion programmes, but is permitted for other accredited programmes.
- Students on all programmes accredited against the requirements for the GBC must complete an empirical psychology project; no exemption may be granted against this piece of work.

RATIONALE FOR INCLUSION

The Society is interested in the ways in which education providers implement their EDI policies. It is particularly important that those progressing to undertake professional training in psychology, and therefore those moving into employment as psychologists, reflect the demographics of the populations with whom they will be working.

Similarly, the Society is keen to promote diversity in psychology students progressing towards careers as academics or researchers. Overall, it is important that psychological knowledge and expertise is reflected across a diverse range of people, and that this diversity is ultimately reflected throughout the Society's membership. Widening access to professional training, including by providing greater flexibility in relation to the order of studies that students undertake, is key to enhancing the diversity of the workforce in the longer term.

GUIDANCE AND SIGNPOSTING

- Chapter B2 of the UK Quality Code for Higher Education (qaa.ac.uk) addresses recruitment, selection and admission to higher education. Chapter B6 also considers assessment of students and the recognition of prior learning. Finally, Part C of the Quality Code outlines expectations around the provision of fit for purpose, accessible and trustworthy information regarding the learning opportunities offered for the benefit of a range of audiences, including applicants and the general public. Providers may find it helpful to review their provision against these resources (qaa.ac.uk).
- The Office for Students is the independent regulator of fair access to higher education in England. Like OfFA, the Society believes that everyone with the potential and ambition to succeed in higher education should have equal opportunity to do so, whatever their income or background (officeforstudents.org.uk). Whilst its remit covers England only, OfFa provides a series of resources on widening access that all providers will find useful.
- The Society declares its commitment to promote EDI and to challenge prejudice and discrimination, and actively promotes a culture of EDI within our discipline. In demonstrating achievement of this standard, education providers are encouraged to hold or be in the process of seeking relevant equality charter marks. Providers of accredited programmes should take steps to identify under-represented groups (officeforstudents.org.uk) and encourage their participation in psychology education and training and in the wider psychological workforce. Individuals' identities are shaped by a range of factors that intersect in different ways, and providers should consider the steps they are able to take to promote and improve the participation of other underrepresented groups and to encourage greater representation (advance-he.ac.uk). Programme teams are encouraged to use equality impact assessments on provision and processes related to all aspects of the student journey, from programme application to degree award.

PROGRAMME STANDARD 5: STUDENT DEVELOPMENT, SUPPORT AND PROFESSIONAL ENGAGEMENT

The programme must be able to articulate an inclusive strategy for supporting all students' personal and professional development.

5.1 The programme must have in place integrated mechanisms for the equitable support of students' holistic personal development.

5.2 The provider must ensure that students are supported at all stages by a proactive personal tutor system (i.e. the personal tutor should initiate a regular programme of meetings with students over the course of the degree). Personal Tutors should be academic members of staff.

5.3 Policies should be in place to direct students to appropriate health and wellbeing support services.

5.4 Systems for student support should empower learners to take personal control of their own development, by providing opportunities for the exercise of choice, decision-making, and responsibility within a supportive environment, in order to promote the development of autonomous and personalised learning and enhance psychological wellbeing.

5.5 The programme should also have an integrated approach to facilitating the ability of students to work collaboratively, as part of a community of learners. This will support students in understanding professional conduct, considering and valuing the perspectives of others, including within and across disciplines.

5.6 Students should have equitable access to discipline-specific professional development, including a range of opportunities for enhancing students' self-awareness and employability. The programme team should be involved in supporting student development of discipline specific and transferable skills. Specific resources should be dedicated to supporting this aspect of the provision. The providers are expected to raise student awareness of careers related to and beyond psychology.

5.7 It is beneficial for work placements or internships to be available to students, as they provide the opportunity to apply subject knowledge, understanding, and skills, thereby enhancing their employability. Where work placements or internships are available, these must be equally accessible and providers must be able to demonstrate this (e.g. through an equality impact assessment).

5.8 Providers must define the subject specific skills (e.g. psychological literacy) and transferable skills developed within their provision (e.g. from a range of learning opportunities and authentic assessments). Providers must also ensure that, as they progress in their studies, students are able to articulate how their learning equips them with transferable and subject-specific skills that are of value to themselves, employers and society. Section 3.17 of the Subject Benchmark Statement for Psychology outlines the importance of generic, transferable skills, and on completion of the programme, graduates should be able to acheive the following:

- communicate effectively using a range of verbal and/or non-verbal methods;
- interact professionally with others, respond inclusively in a manner sensitive to the needs and expectations of a diverse range of audiences;

- demonstrate numerical reasoning skills including the analysis, presentation and interpretation of quantitative data;
- demonstrate the ability to analyse, interpret and present qualitative data;
- demonstrate digital literacy through the use of online databases and analytic software, and digital approaches to personal and professional development;
- understand the function and role of AI in the context of learning and teaching, problems solving and working practices;
- understand the ethical, practical and legal issues associated with the collection, management, storage, processing, sharing and presentation of information, including in digital formats;
- retrieve and organise information found in a range of sources (for example, academic books, policy documents and non-academic sources) while recognising the different perspectives and influences that amplify or marginalise certain forms of knowledge and evidence;
- demonstrate inclusive and collaborative working and reflect on the value of engagement with a variety of views in reaching consensus in solutions to problems;
- reflect on and articulate personal strengths and areas for development and identify how these may be addressed; and
- take ownership for one's own learning, employability and development, including effective personal planning and project management skills.

These competencies represent a coherent set of knowledge, skills and values that underpin students' psychological literacy and which enable them to apply psychology to real life contexts in an inclusive and professional manner. These scientific, critical thinking and ethical skills encapsulate the contributions a psychology graduate can make to the workplace and to society more generally. Please refer to Section 3.16 of the Subject Benchmark Statement for Psychology which outlines the subject-specific skills students graduating with an honours degree in psychology should be able to achieve.

5.9 The programme must provide students with information on the benefits of completing an accredited programme, and gaining membership of the Society at the appropriate level. Providers should emphasise the benefits of Society membership for students' and graduates' professional development.

RATIONALE FOR INCLUSION

This standard is included because enhancing personal and professional development is of value to students, society, and employers. Ultimately, it supports students in understanding and fulfilling their goals and aspirations. Education providers may link with local and/or national employers, as well as practitioners within and related to psychology and other Professional, Statutory and Regulatory Bodies (PSRBs) in a variety of ways. The Society is keen to develop its understanding of these approaches through partnership visits. Additionally, the Society believes it is important that education providers communicate the benefits of completing an accredited programme to their students along with the benefits of being engaged with the BPS. The Society recognises graduates' qualifications and reflects their aspiration to represent the highest possible professional standards.

GUIDANCE AND SIGNPOSTING

- Chapter B4 of the UK Quality Code for Higher Education (qaa.ac.uk) addresses enabling student development and achievement. Chapter B3 also considers learning and teaching, and specifically emphasises the need to enable every student to monitor their progress and further their academic development through the provision of regular opportunities to reflect on feedback and engage in dialogue with staff. Finally, Part C of the UK Quality Code for Higher Education addresses the information that should be provided to students about their programme of study and their achievements. Providers may find it helpful to review their provision against these resources (qaa.ac.uk).
- The Society's role is to develop and support the discipline of psychology, and to disseminate psychological knowledge to the public and policy makers. Joining the Society provides opportunities for students to contribute to the Society's work and discipline, and benefit from the resources the Society provides as they develop professionally.
- Completion of an accredited programme offers graduates a clear route to Society membership at the appropriate level, and therefore access to the full range of membership benefits, including a variety of services, publications, conferences, training and networking opportunities. Society membership also presents graduates with opportunities for developing and influencing the profession as leaders in their field in the future. For more information on the benefits of Society membership, see bps.org.uk/membership.
- In demonstrating their achievement of this standard, education providers should have an integrated and equitable approach to students' personal and professional development. This is a joint endeavor between the Psychology programme team and the provider's Career Service.

PROGRAMME STANDARD 6: ACADEMIC LEADERSHIP AND PROGRAMME DELIVERY

The education provider must have appropriate human resources in place to support the effective delivery of the programme, including appointing an appropriately qualified and experienced Programme Director/Leader.

6.1 STAFFING STRATEGY

6.1.1 Education providers must be able to outline a clear strategy in relation to the leadership and co-ordination of the programme. The Programme Director/Programme Leader must operate with a level of autonomy that enables them to effectively oversee the programme's governance, equality impact and delivery.

6.1.2 Providers need to demonstrate that their overall staffing strategy supports the long-term sustainability of the provision, and the capacity to continue to meet the Society's accreditation standards on an ongoing basis. In the interests of promoting a holistic learning experience for students, the Society expects the core programme delivery team to be located predominantly in one department or on one site. Blended and online provision should be able to demonstrate a comparable and cohesive student experience.

6.1.3 Programmes must have in place sufficient appropriately qualified staff in order to be able to provide a learning experience that meets students' needs, and which is underpinned by competent, research-informed teaching. The staff team as a whole need to be able to deliver (i.e. teach and assess) across the required programme content (see Programme Standard 2) at the appropriate level and supervise students' empirical psychology projects. They should develop students' understanding of the application of their psychological literacy for students' future career(s).

6.1.4 Education providers must be able to outline the steps they are taking to monitor and advance equality, and to improve the career prospects of underrepresented groups within their Department/School.

6.2 QUALIFICATIONS OF PROGRAMME DIRECTOR/LEADER AND STAFF

6.2.1 **Programme Director/Leader:** The Programme Director/Leader holds overall professional and academic responsibility for ensuring that the programme meets the Society's standards, and for maintaining the accreditation of the programme. The Programme Director/Leader must have the programme as their major commitment, and have time available to ensure its effective and efficient running. Where the Programme Director/Leader is not employed on a 1FTE contract, measures must be in place to ensure effective organisation of the programme and timely responses to staff and student queries in their absence.

6.2.2 For undergraduate, conversion and integrated Master's programmes, the Programme Director/Leader should be either a Chartered psychologist, or eligible for Chartered psychologist status. Information on the requirements for becoming a Chartered Member of the Society can be found at bps.org.uk/cpsychol.

6.2.3 The Programme Director/Leader must have knowledge and experience of the delivery of accredited undergraduate, conversion and/or integrated Master's psychology programmes, with appropriate academic and management skills, and must make a contribution to the delivery of the programme.

6.2.4 **Programme staff:** For undergraduate, conversion and integrated Master's programmes:

- All staff contributing to the delivery of accredited programmes will hold, as a minimum, an appropriate postgraduate qualification in psychology and/or a demonstrable track record in research or other scholarly activity of relevance to psychology.
- The empirical project in psychology must be supervised, taught and examined by psychologists or suitably qualified postgraduates. The Society considers individuals suitably qualified to supervise the empirical project if they hold, as a minimum, a postgraduate qualification in psychology and/or a demonstrable track record of research or other scholarly activity of relevance to psychology.
- Graduate Teaching Assistants (GTAs) or equivalent may not carry sole responsibility for project supervision and assessment.

6.3 STAFF STUDENT RATIO

6.3.1 Education providers should provide a calculation of their current Staff Student Ratio (SSR) in the evidence they submit in support of an application for accreditation, or in advance of a partnership visit. Undergraduate, conversion and integrated Master's programmes must operate a staff student ratio of no greater than 1:20, based on FTEs.

6.3.2 Where staff have other duties (e.g. other teaching or practice commitments) these must be taken into account in setting staffing levels and must be such that they do not interfere with the execution of the major responsibility of programme delivery. They must also be reflected appropriately in any SSR return.

6.3.3 Programmes with smaller cohort sizes will require an enhanced SSR, less than twenty students to one member of staff. This is to ensure that the programme staff are able to undertake the range of tasks required in order to deliver a quality student experience (see 6.4).

6.4 STAFFING LEVELS AND DEVELOPMENT

6.4.1 There are key roles and functions that the Society considers are essential to the effective and efficient delivery of an accredited programme. Programmes must therefore have sufficient staff with enough time allocated to carry out the range of tasks that are associated with: teaching; organising, co-ordinating and monitoring placements (if appropriate); training and supporting supervisors or other assessors; research supervision; marking; providing personal support to students; supporting their professional development; and liaising with employers, PSRBs, visiting speakers and other external stakeholders.

6.4.2 In the interests of providing a positive and coherent student experience, education providers must ensure that programme staff are readily accessible to students, and, where applicable (e.g. international and online provision), that students have clear guidance on arrangements for liaising with staff outside of any core contact hours.

6.4.3 All programmes must pay particular attention to ensuring that staffing levels are such that students receive research supervision at a level consistent with the programme's aims and that research supervision loads for staff are appropriate to enable them to provide adequate supervision at the required level.

6.4.4 Providers of undergraduate, conversion and integrated Master's programmes are expected to have in place the following staffing resources as a minimum:

- There must be at least five members of academic staff who, together, are able to carry out the range of tasks associated with programme delivery, including delivery across the GBC curriculum (see above).
- There must be a minimum of 3 FTE staff in total, although providers should be aware that programmes with small cohort sizes are likely to require an enhanced SSR (see 6.3.2).
- There must be at least one member of staff who is employed as a 1FTE on the programme.
- The provider should be able to show that the pool of staff are able to demonstrate the relevant subject knowledge to deliver and assess the depth and breadth of the programme.
- The contribution of GTAs (or equivalent) and hourly paid staff should not be more than 20% of the total staff FTE.

6.5 PROFESSIONAL SERVICES SUPPORT STAFF

6.5.1 Programmes must have access to sufficient dedicated administrative, technical or other learning support staff to support their effective delivery. For undergraduate, conversion and integrated Master's degrees, programme delivery should be supported by the following:

- There should be at least 2 FTE administrative and secretarial staff, at least 1 FTE of which should be dedicated to psychology. Please refer to the *Supplementary guidance for providers of accredited programmes on the roles and contributions of professional administrative staff*
- There should be at least 1 FTE dedicated psychology technician, who needs to be able to support students' experimental and practical work as well as providing any more general technical support. Please refer to the Supplementary Guidance on the Roles and Contributions of Psychology Technical Staff.

For larger provision (greater than around 400FTE students), additional resources are expected. Programmes should identify the nature and extent of these additional resources.

Where shared or distributed arrangements for support staff are in place, the education provider must demonstrate their equivalence to the minimum standards outlined above. The education provider must be able to demonstrate that the support that is provided is sufficient to meet the needs of the provision in question.

6.5.2 Where accredited provision is being delivered online, in a blended manner, across several campuses, or being delivered by another provider (e.g. franchise arrangement), providers must be able to outline a clear strategy in relation to the leadership and co-ordination of the programme, and evidence that they meet the criteria outlined above.

6.5.3 For undergraduate, conversion and integrated Master's programmes, Psychology Technicians take responsibility for supporting research and other practical work. The focus lies with subject-specific technical input to student provision, especially in relation to practical research activities.

6.6 STAFF PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

6.6.1 Staff are entitled to expect an institutional culture which values and rewards professionalism and scholarship, and which provides equitable access to development opportunities which assist them in their support for student learning and support. Institutions should support initial and continuing professional development (CPD) for all staff (academic, administrative and technical) and provide accessible resources to allow staff to look after their mental health and wellbeing.

6.6.2 All members of programme teams are expected to undertake CPD that is necessary to their role within the programme, and, where appropriate, relevant to their professional practice. It is expected that this would include undertaking relevant research, knowledge transfer and other scholarly activity, and/or attendance at relevant conferences. Opportunities for development should be available to all staff who are engaged in, or are supporting, teaching, research and scholarship These activities should be reflected in the relevant workload models to ensure that appropriate time is allocated to these activities.

6.6.3 Education providers must have a training and mentoring strategy in place to support early-career staff and GTAs and enable the CPD of existing staff. This should equip them to undertake core roles, including teaching, supervision and assessment of students' work and student support roles.

6.6.4 Education providers should have in place a strategy for providing CPD for staff who wish to take a role in providing career guidance, personal and professional development and support students' development of work-focused employability skills etc.

RATIONALE FOR INCLUSION

This standard is included as contact with, and support, from sufficient numbers of appropriately qualified and experienced staff whose professional development is well supported will contribute significantly to the quality of the overall student experience. Additionally, the leadership and co-ordination of the programme is central to shaping students' experience and their development as psychologists or professionals in related areas.

GUIDANCE AND SIGNPOSTING

- Where appropriate, Programme Directors/Leaders may be supported in aspects of their role by colleagues with complementary skills and experience to their own. Education providers may wish to consider the roles that other programme team members may take in relation to the leadership and co-ordination of the programme as part of their staff development strategy, particularly in connection with longer-term succession planning or to support the development of leadership potential.
- In the interests of the longer-term sustainable delivery of the programme, providers should have contingency plans in place to ensure that an appropriately qualified and experienced individual has been identified who could deputise for the Programme Director/Leaders should the need arise (e.g. sickness absence, parental leave, sabbatical).
- The Society supports the inclusive principles set out in Inclusivity and Diversity Awards and would encourage providers of accredited programmes to pursue gaining recognition. Individuals' identities are shaped by a range of factors that intersect in different ways, and providers should consider the steps they are able to take to promote and improve the career prospects of other underrepresented groups and to encourage greater representation. (advance-he.ac.uk).
- Programme providers are encouraged to consult the Society's *Supplementary Guidance on the Roles and Contributions of Psychology Technical Staff* (2014), and its *Supplementary Guidance for Providers of Accredited Programmes on the Roles and Contributions of Professional Administrative Staff* (2017).
- The Society has produced Supplementary Guidance on Staffing for Society-Accredited Psychology Programmes, available at available on request from the Partnership and Accreditation Team. This is designed to help providers meet the Society's staffing standards and calculate their SSR.
- Chapter B3 of the UK Quality Code for Higher Education (qaa.ac.uk) addresses learning and teaching, and specifically emphasises the need for higher education providers to assure themselves that everyone involved in teaching or supporting student learning is appropriately qualified, supported and developed. This includes: appropriate and current practitioner knowledge and an understanding of the subject they teach and of the disciplinary scholarship appropriate to the academic level of the students they are teaching; and the necessary skills and experience to facilitate learning in all of the students they are interacting with, and to use approaches grounded in sound learning and teaching scholarship and practice. Providers may find it helpful to review their provision against these resources (Chapter B3 Indicator 4, qaa.ac.uk).
- Technicians play an important role in relation to teaching, learning and research development. This may include: the development of new technology or the novel application of existing technology to enhance the student experience and their development of research skills, or to resolve problems in relation to these; the development of new materials or systems to support the student research experience; provision of support to lecturing or other staff within the department; project management skills, including leading a team and liaising with key stakeholders both internal and external to the department; and dissemination or publication of aspects of their technical support.

PROGRAMME STANDARD 7: DISCIPLINE-SPECIFIC RESOURCES

The education provider must have appropriate resources, including discipline-specific resources, in place to support the effective delivery of the programme.

7.1 Education providers should ensure that students are advised of the discipline-specific and general learning resources and facilities to which they have access, (which may include: placements, mentoring, coaching, work-based learning opportunities etc.) and are provided with the necessary support to enable them to make appropriate use of these. Resources should be accessible to all students and encourage an approach to lifelong-learning.

7.2 Education providers must offer students access to learning resources that are appropriate to the range of theoretical and practical work that will allow the development of psychological literacy and the application of psychological skills and knowledge reflecting the diversity of the discipline.

7.2.1 To ensure the quality of provision, education providers of undergraduate, conversion and integrated Master's programmes must have in place adequate and dedicated laboratory space and equipment appropriate to their mode of delivery, which are resilient and sustainable across rapidly changing circumstances. This will include facilities to enable students to carry out experimental and other appropriate practical work in a range of GBC curriculum areas, and must include facilities for teaching practical skills to small and large groups, in addition to supporting individual students' empirical work.

7.2.2 The Society would expect the learning resources provided to include a minimum of 2000 relevant psychology books (e-books or hard copies), a substantial number of which have been published within the last five years; this figure may also include multiple copies of, or licences for, key texts. Students should also have access to a minimum of 50 current full-text electronic and/or printed journals reflecting balanced coverage across the GBC curriculum. This should include both current and back-dated issues.

7.2.3 The Society expects there to be resources related to work-based learning and employability. This might include the provision of or, support with finding placements, internships or voluntary work, and resources, which give an insight into careers, including those which demonstrate how psychological literacy is used in careers beyond psychology.

7.2.4 Online and Blended Learning programmes must be able demonstrate comparability of student experience across different delivery modes with regards to access to relevant resources (e.g. support for practical work).

RATIONALE FOR INCLUSION

This standard is included because the learning experience must be underpinned by access to resources that are appropriate to the psychology programme(s), and their mode of delivery, offered by the education provider and to develop students' employability skills. The availability of appropriate resources is key to the delivery of psychology as a science, with associated levels of practical work culminating in students' completion of individual research at the appropriate level.

GUIDANCE AND SIGNPOSTING

- Resources will normally include teaching, tutorial and laboratory space, learning resources (such as texts and journals, available in hard copy and/or electronically, computing facilities), psychological testing materials, specialist equipment supporting psychological research, software supporting data collection and analysis in psychology research, and other IT and/or audio-visual facilities (e.g. to enable the recording of practice role plays and assessment tasks), as appropriate to the provision in question.
- Chapter B3 of the UK Quality Code for Higher Education (qaa.ac.uk) addresses learning and teaching, and specifically sets out the expectation that education providers, working with their staff, students and other stakeholders, articulate and systematically review and enhance the provision of learning opportunities and teaching practices, so that every student is enabled to develop as an independent student, study their chosen subject(s) in depth and enhance their capacity for analytical, critical and creative thinking. In particular, there is an expectation that providers maintain physical, virtual and social learning environments that are safe, accessible and reliable for every student, promoting dignity, courtesy and respect in their use (Chapter B3 Indicator 6, qaa.ac.uk).

PROGRAMME STANDARD 8: QUALITY ASSURANCE AND GOVERNANCE

The education provider's quality assurance systems must make regular provision for the periodic review of the validity and relevance of the programme, such that it continues to reflect the Society's standards and meets the needs of the programme's stakeholders.

8.1 ASSURANCE AND ENHANCEMENT OF QUALITY

8.1.1 The quality management mechanisms that are in place should provide for periodic review and equality impact assessment of the programme's aims and intended learning outcomes and content, the strategies associated with programme delivery, and the assessment methods that are used to evaluate students' achievement of the learning outcomes. Overall, quality management mechanisms should ensure that the programme continues to reflect contemporary learning, research and practice in psychology.

8.1.2 Providers should have access to data documenting the student journey, including recruitment, retention, progression, award, and graduate outcomes, to allow for the identification of inequality between groups of students. Analysis of such data will enable providers to make the changes required to enhance equality, diversity, and inclusion.

8.1.3 Programmes will appoint appropriate External Examiners whose expertise will be of relevance to the breadth and depth of provision being offered. They will ensure that External Examiners are provided with adequate information to support their role, and that systems are in place to monitor action that is taken in response to any issues raised. Where providers deliver more than one programme, separate External Examiner reports are required for each programme. Where multiple programmes share core modules one report can be submitted but this should contain comments on the students experience on each programme.

8.1.4 For undergraduate, conversion and integrated Master's programmes, a minimum of two appropriately qualified External Examiners should be appointed, with expertise that covers the breadth of the programme(s) (and therefore the work that they will be expected to examine).

8.1.5 For programmes involved in international delivery (e.g. franchise arrangements, overseas campus delivery) quality procedures should reflect on potential risks to programme delivery to ensure the resiliency of the programme and quality of the student experience. Programmes should reflect the cultural context in which they are delivered, and providers should consider the role of the partnerships in relation to sustainable development.

8.2 STAKEHOLDER ENGAGEMENT:

8.2.1 Stakeholders (e.g. students) should be encouraged to provide feedback on the design and delivery of the programme via the quality management mechanisms that are in place. There may also be involvement from stakeholders in the co-design of the programme. Programmes should identify ways in which any difficulties identified

(whether as informal or formal complaints) may be satisfactorily resolved, and changes to current systems and practices made where appropriate.

8.2.2 Both formal and informal mechanisms of quality assurance should be in place, including regular documented staff student liaison meetings. This approach to quality assurance should ensure that diversity of the student experience is represented. There should be clear communication with students and other relevant stakeholders regarding how their feedback has been acted on and has contributed to the quality management and enhancement process.

RATIONALE FOR INCLUSION

This standard is included because Accreditation through Partnership relies upon education providers having in place robust quality management and enhancement mechanisms that facilitate self-evaluation of programme design and delivery against the Society's accreditation standards and other indicators of academic standards. The Society recognises education providers' quality management mechanisms as a reliable source of evidence of continued achievement of the standards.

GUIDANCE AND SIGNPOSTING

- Part A of the UK Quality Code for Higher Education (qaa.ac.uk) addresses setting and maintaining academic standards. Part C addresses the information that providers set out in relation to their arrangements for managing academic standards and quality assurance and enhancement, and the records they maintain of all arrangements for delivering higher education with others. Providers may also find it helpful to refer to a further five chapters from Part B of the Quality Code (qaa.ac.uk):
  - Chapter B5: Student engagement, and in particular the role of students as partners in the assurance and enhancement of their educational experience.
  - Chapter B7: External examining
  - Chapter B8: Programme monitoring and review
  - Chapter B9: Academic appeals and student complaints, and in particular ensuring that students have opportunities to raise matters of concern without risk of disadvantage
  - Chapter B10: Managing higher education provision with others, which specifically highlights that degree-awarding bodies have ultimate responsibility for academic standards and the quality of learning opportunities irrespective of where these are delivered or who provides them.
- External peer review offers a valuable perspective upon the ways in which the programme compares to others of a similar nature nationally. With this in mind, enabling the Society to have sight of internal quality review reports and External Examiners' reports, and the programme's response to these, allows our reviewers to gain insight into the extent to which the education provider's quality management mechanisms function effectively for the benefit of students, and the discipline as a whole.
- All providers are encouraged to consider the ways in which employer feedback might be harnessed as part of the quality management and programme development process.



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